

The Girl from the Poorhouse

The true story of Mary “Marietta” Blackwell, 1877–1938, and of her mother Ann — from a Liverpool steerage deck to the friends who carried her home

Researched and written from original records by Robert Babcock

In memory of his great-great-grandmother

The story Grandma told

For as long as anyone can remember, our family carried a fragment of a story. Grandma Bernadine (Brand) Babcock said that her grandmother — Marietta Blackwell, who married Jacob Brand — had been *an orphan from Ireland*. Nobody knew who her parents were. There was even a whispered rumor, never verified, that they might have been clergy back in Ireland.

Family stories like this usually dissolve when you go looking for paper. This one did the opposite. The first edition of this paper, written in August 2026, recovered the thing the family never had: her mother’s name. In the weeks since, the records have given up far more — the mother’s whole life, from the ship that likely carried her out of Ireland at fifteen, to the Utica household that took her in, to the friends who claimed her body at the end so that she would not lie in a pauper’s grave. The second edition told that story complete, and corrected one detail the first edition got wrong — a correction that made the story better, not worse. This third edition adds the part that is still unfolding: the active hunt to trace Ann back to the very parish in Ireland she walked out of — the leads we are following right now, and our best guesses, plainly labeled as guesses, about where she came from.

A three-year-old in the poorhouse

The search began with a strange entry in the 1880 federal census. In Rome, Oneida County, New York, the census taker walked through an institution whose name he wrote across the top of the page: *Oneida County Poorhouse*. Among the residents — paupers and invalids born in Ireland, Germany, and England — he recorded a little girl.

1880 UNITED STATES
CENSUS · ONEIDA CO
UNTY POORHOUSE, R
OME, N. Y.

E.D. 112, p. 61B

NAME	<i>Blackwell, Mary</i>
AGE	3
CONDITION	“Homeless”

A three-year-old, marked *homeless*, in a county poorhouse. This was our Marietta — the birth date matches her later records to the day: February 2, 1877, New York. Every document she left behind as an adult — census after census, and finally her death certificate — would say the same thing about her parents: *Unknown*.

But the poorhouse kept its own books. And in those books, we found her mother.

Ann Blackwell of Ireland

New York law required every county poorhouse to keep a standardized record of each inmate. On September 30, 1876 — five months before Mary was born — the keeper of the Oneida County Poor House filled out a form for a new arrival.

RECORD OF INMATES · ONEIDA COUNTY POORHOUSE		No. 446 · adm. Sept. 30, 1876
NAME	<i>Ann Blackwell</i>	
AGE/CONDITION	<i>30 · Single</i>	
BIRTHPLACE	Ireland	
OCCUPATION	<i>House servant</i>	
RELATIVES	<i>None</i>	
CAUSE OF DEPENDENCE	<i>“Having young child”</i>	

Ann Blackwell was an unmarried Irish immigrant, working as a house servant, alone in America, and four months pregnant. She entered the poorhouse that autumn, and on February 2, 1877, inside its walls, she gave birth to a daughter: Mary. At the bottom of the form, the superintendent added several lines in his own hand:

“This is the second child this woman has had. The first one she swore on a boy by the name of Martin, and he paid... about \$20 in the hands of the County Superintendent, as the child died some time ago. I do not know what can be done about this one, as I understand she can not swear who is its father.”

SUPERINTENDENT'S REMARKS, ONEIDA COUNTY POORHOUSE RECORD, 1876

Those sentences explain a mystery that ran through sixty years of records: Mary's father was never named. They also tell us Ann had already buried a first baby. It is worth reading the last line carefully. Ann knew how to swear paternity — she had done it once, successfully, and the county had collected support money on her behalf. That she “can not swear” the second time may mean she did not know; it may equally mean the father was a man a servant girl could not afford to name. The record permits both readings, and honesty requires us to keep both. Either way, the form preserved what no one else did: that Marietta's mother existed, that she had a name, and that she came from Ireland.

Together, then taken

The first edition of this paper repeated what the census index showed: that three-year-old Mary was enumerated *alone*. That turned out to be an artifact of the database. When we later pulled the original 1880 page and read every handwritten line, the truth was waiting a few entries away, in the same dwelling, on the same sheet of paper:

1880 UNITED STATES CENSUS · THE SAME P AGE		E.D. 112, p. 61B, dw. 90
NAME	Blackwell, Ann · age 32 · born Ireland	
CONDITION	“Destitute”	

Mother and daughter were in the poorhouse together. Mary was never abandoned there. For the first three and a half years of her life, whatever else that grim building was, her mother was in it with her.

What separated them was not a choice but a statute. New York's *Children's Law* of 1875 barred children over the age of two from being kept in county poorhouses — a reform meant to save children from growing up in institutions full of the sick and the destitute. In practice it meant the county was required to remove Mary from her mother. Oneida County's practice, described in the State Board of Charities reports of the period, was to move such children to Utica asylums and “thence place them in families.” Mary was sent to the *House of the Good Shepherd* in Utica — founded in 1872 by the women of Trinity Episcopal Church, and the only institution in Utica that took the youngest children. It was an Episcopal house, but its own reports say it received “many Roman Catholics.” Ann did not give Mary up. The State

of New York, with the best of intentions, took her.

Johanna Mary of Columbia, Illinois

From the House of the Good Shepherd, Mary's trail crosses 900 miles west to the German Catholic farming country of Monroe County, Illinois — and there, family memory and the paper record finally meet. In 2026 we found the adoption stated in print, in a county biographical volume published when Mary was seventeen:

"[John A. Pfeffer and his wife] also gave homes to two adopted children: Elizabeth Smith... and Johanna Mary, who is still living with them."

PORTRAIT AND BIOGRAPHICAL RECORD OF RANDOLPH, JACKSON, PERRY AND MONROE COUNTIES, ILLINOIS, 1894

John A. Pfeffer (1844–1908), a general merchant of Columbia, and his wife **Johanna K. (Funk) Pfeffer** (1845–1915) raised fourteen children of their own — and still took in two more who had none. They were Roman Catholic, the son of a Bavarian immigrant; a devout, prosperous, crowded household. The 1900 census finds Mary there under the name the family gave her: "*Jennie Pfeffer, 24, adopted daughter, born Feb. 1876, New York.*" And that solves a small puzzle that had run through her later records — why she sometimes appears as "Johanna M." or "Marietta J.": her adoptive parents named her *Johanna Mary*, after her new mother. The poorhouse baby from Rome, New York, grew up as a merchant's daughter named for the woman who chose her.

When she married, she did it under her legal birth name: on her 1904 Monroe County record she is *Marietta Blackwell, age 27*, bride of **Jacob Brand**, a Columbia contractor, son of Joseph Brand of Baden — a Union veteran who had served in the 1st U.S. Reserve Corps Missouri Infantry in 1861. But when St. Louis newspapers printed her death notice decades later, they called her "*Marietta Brand (nee Pfeffer)*" — because to everyone who knew her, the Pfeffers were her family. Both names were true. And the truest record of all is in the ground at Immaculate Conception Catholic Cemetery in Columbia: Marietta and Jacob lie in row six — **directly behind John A. and Johanna Pfeffer in row five**. She was buried, by choice, at her adoptive parents' backs.

Her life

Marietta and Jacob began their married life in Columbia. The 1910 census finds them there with a small son — **David**, born about 1906, who would grow up to be Grandma Bernadine's father. Two more children followed: **Marietta** (born about 1911; her married name appears as *Rohlfing* on her father's 1942 death certificate, where she signed as his informant) and **Vern Harry** ("Laverne," born about

1919). By 1920 the family had crossed the river to St. Louis, settling on the city’s south side, where Jacob worked as a contractor.

She lived the rest of her life there. On the night of November 1, 1938, at St. Louis City Hospital, Marietta died of a cerebral embolism at age 61. Her death certificate — the official, final account of her life — contains two lines that carry the whole weight of her story:

MISSOURI CERTIFICATE OF DEATH · ST. LOUIS		No. 37226 · Nov. 1, 1938
NAME	Maryetta Brand · wife of Jacob Brand	
BORN	February 2, 1877 · New York	
NAME OF FATHER	Unknown	
MAIDEN NAME OF MOTHER	Unknown	
BURIAL	November 5, 1938 · Columbia, Illinois	

Even at the end, no one at her bedside could name her parents. For eighty-eight years, “Unknown” was the last word on where she came from. It isn’t anymore.

What became of Ann

The first edition ended Ann’s story where the poorhouse registers ended it. We can now follow her the rest of the way. After losing Mary to the Children’s Law, Ann did what she had always done: she worked. The Utica city directories of 1889–1891 list “Anna Blackwell, laundress,” living in a rear tenement at 55 Charlotte Street — a single Irish washerwoman, keeping herself, asking nothing of anyone.

By 1900 she had found a better place. The census that year records the household of David E. Owens — a young Utica fireman — and his wife **Lucy**, at 305 Sunset Avenue in West Utica. Living with them:

1900 UNITED STATES CENSUS · 305 SUNSET AVE., UTICA WARD 11		Owens household
NAME	Annie Blackwell · Servant · single	
BORN	June 1854 · Ireland · parents born Ireland	
IMMIGRATED	1880	
MOTHER OF HOW MANY CHILDREN	0	

Read those last two lines knowing what we know. Ann told the census taker she had arrived in 1880 and had never borne a child. Neither was true — in June 1880 she was in the Rome poorhouse beside her three-year-old daughter. This was the story she told the household she lived in, and probably everyone in her later life: a respectable servant's biography with the poorhouse and the babies cut out. She carried Mary as a secret, and she carried her alone.

A word of caution about that census label, because it is the only place any record calls Ann a servant. "Servant" is the enumerator's word — in 1900 it was virtually the only box available for a non-relative woman who kept house under someone else's roof, and it cannot tell us whether Ann drew wages or was simply given a room and a place at the table in exchange for the work of her hands. What the records do show is that Lucy's house had a habit of taking people in. She kept her first husband's mother under that roof for twenty-four years, until the old woman died at 305 Sunset in 1901; a stepdaughter's wedding reception filled the same parlor in 1908. And in no other record we have found do the Owens keep a servant at all — this was a fireman's household, not a grand one. Whether Ann was staff, or a boarder who helped, or an aging woman sheltered partly out of kindness — or whether it began as one and became the other — the paper trail cannot say, and the reader is free to weigh it. What is beyond doubt is only this: she lived there, she worked, and the connection held.

In March 1905, too feeble to work any longer, Ann was admitted to the county almshouse one last time. On the line for *relatives or friends*, the keeper wrote the only name Ann had to give: **"Mrs. David Owens, 305 Sunset Ave., Utica"** — Lucy, the woman of the house on Sunset Avenue. Not kin, but the closest thing to family she had — and the form's own word for it, *friends*, may be the most honest word in all her records.



The women's day room of the Oneida County Almshouse, Rome, N.Y., photographed in 1900 — the ward Ann knew, five years before her final admission. (Harvard Art Museums / Fogg Museum collection.)

Ann died in the almshouse at 7 o'clock on the morning of October 31, 1905 — New York death certificate no. 46049, “a complication of diseases.” She was about 55, or 59, depending which of her own accounts you believe. An almshouse death in 1905 ordinarily meant one thing: an anonymous numbered stake in the county plot. Instead, the Rome Daily Sentinel printed eleven words that change how her story ends:

“The remains were taken to Utica, where she formerly resided, for interment.”

ROMEDAILYSENTINEL, OCTOBER 31, 1905

Someone claimed her. Someone paid to bring her body thirteen miles home to Utica and bury her there — almost certainly the Owens household, the “friends” on her admission form, and most likely in consecrated Catholic ground. The woman who told the poorhouse in 1876 that she had *no relatives*, who was recorded arriving alone at fifteen, did not go to a pauper's grave. At the very end, she belonged to somebody.

The girl on the ship

Ann told the almshouse in 1905 that she had been in the United States “about 40 years” — an emigration around 1865. In August 2026 we went looking for the ship. In the Castle Garden—era passenger lists for the Port of New York, across every arrival from 1861 to 1869, every port and every spelling, exactly **one** matching passenger appears:

PASSENGERMANIFEST SHIPSCOTLAND· LIVERPOOLTONEW YORK		arr. May 28, 1866
NAME	Ann Blackwell	
AGE	15	
OCCUPATION	Spinster	
TRAVELING WITH	No one — alone in steerage	

The arithmetic is almost uncanny: May 1866 to March 1905 is thirty-eight years and ten months — “about 40 years” on the nose. Age fifteen puts her birth at about 1851, the midpoint of every age she ever gave. On the manifest she stands wedged between a big Irish family and a column of single laborers — a teenage girl alone on a steerage deck, three weeks out of Liverpool, which was the standard route out of Ireland (an unrecorded ferry from Dublin or Drogheda, then a Liverpool packet to New York).

One honest caveat belongs in the record: the manifest’s nationality column marks her “English” — but the same clerk’s ditto marks make an Englishman of “Bryan Hart” two lines below her, a name about as English as a shamrock. Liverpool clerks were careless with that column, and every American record of Ann’s life — every census, both almshouse forms, her own statements about her parents — says Ireland. We hold this record as her *probable* arrival, and it is attached to her profile as such. If it is her, then the whole shape of her life is visible in one glance: she crossed the ocean alone at fifteen, and she was buried by friends at fifty-nine. Nobody carried her at the start. Somebody did at the end.

The road back to Ireland

Where in Ireland? We do not know yet — but for the first time, the question has edges. The surname Blackwell turns out to be genuinely *rare* in Ireland: the 1901 census of the whole island counted just 152 people bearing it. And though the name is English in origin, the Irish Blackwells were **majority Catholic** — 92 of the 152 — which fits Ann exactly. Griffith’s Valuation, the great property survey taken across Ireland in the very years of Ann’s childhood, shows only about 57 Blackwell households in the entire country, and they bunch into three clusters:

Before guessing, it helps to say exactly what any candidate parish must account for. Ann was born somewhere around 1846–1854 (most likely about 1851), to parents who were both Irish-born. She was Catholic. She left as a girl of about fifteen, alone, through Liverpool, in 1866 — the year after the American Civil War ended and the emigrant ships filled again. And she carried a rare English-origin surname that her family had held onto through the Famine. With those constraints, here are our best guesses — ranked, and offered as guesses, nothing more:

First guess: County Louth — the parish of Dunleer. The densest Blackwell cluster in all of Ireland sat in the mid-Louth countryside: fourteen households, seven of them in Dunleer parish alone, still on the land in 1854 — meaning they survived the Famine in place, right in Ann’s birth window. This was overwhelmingly Catholic small-farm country, so those Blackwells were almost certainly Catholic like Ann. And Louth’s emigrants characteristically left exactly the way Ann did: the ferry from Drogheda or Dublin, then a Liverpool packet — the *Scotland’s* route precisely. Best of all for us, Dunleer’s Catholic baptism register survives from October 1847, squarely covering the years Ann would have been carried to the font. If we had to put a single pin in the map of Ireland, it goes in Dunleer.

Second guess: County Limerick. Sixteen households — the largest county total — centered on the Cappamore–Murroe district in the east of the county, with a few families in Limerick city’s parishes. Rural east-Limerick Blackwells would very likely have been Catholic, and Munster fed the post-Famine emigrant stream heavily. It ranks second only because the routes from Limerick ran more often through Queenstown than Liverpool.

Third guess — and the strangest: County Clare. Ten households in the north of the county, around Ennistymon and Kilshanny — plus the one thing no other county has: a documented, centuries-old *Catholic* Blackwell family of Ennis, a prosperous line with, of all things, **clergy connections**. We note that with care rather than excitement: it proves nothing about our Ann, and many Clare registers begin too late to hold her baptism. But it is striking that the one place in Ireland with a known Catholic Blackwell tradition tied to the clergy is also a fair match for Grandma Bernadine’s strangest, least explicable detail — the whispered rumor that Marietta’s people “*were possibly clergy in Ireland.*” If Ann’s trail ever runs to Clare, that old whisper will deserve a second listen.

Three counties, a dozen parishes, and surviving baptism registers: that is no longer a haystack. That is a search plan.

Five generations from the poorhouse door

● **Ann Blackwell (abt. 1846–51, Ireland – Oct. 31, 1905, Rome, N.Y.)**

Crossed alone at fifteen; house servant, laundress, mother; buried in Utica by the friends who took her in

■ **Mary “Marietta” Blackwell Brand (1877, Rome, N.Y. – 1938, St. Louis)**

Born in the poorhouse; raised as Johanna Mary by the Pfeffers of Columbia, Ill.; married Jacob Brand, 1904

■ **David Brand (abt. 1906, Columbia, Ill. –)**

Her firstborn; later of Monrovia, California

■ **Bernadine (Brand) Babcock (1924, St. Louis – 2022, Portland, Ore.)**

Who kept the story alive and told it to her grandson

■ **Robert Babcock & family**

Who went looking — and found them both

It is worth pausing on what this line survived. An immigrant girl who crossed an ocean alone at fifteen. A daughter born in a poorhouse, separated from her mother by an act of the legislature, carried west and raised by strangers who became family. Within two generations, their descendants were homeowners, contractors, radio operators, servicemen. Grandma Bernadine was Marietta's granddaughter — she was fourteen when Marietta died, old enough to have known her, and the story she passed down was not folklore. It was memory. Nearly every word of it has now been proved on paper.

The leads we are following

This is not a cold case. Every lead below is open, and several are already in motion. They are listed in the order we expect them to pay off.

In New York:

1. *Ann's death certificate, no. 46049.* Filed at Rome in October 1905 and orderable from the Rome city clerk, it has printed lines for her father's name and her mother's maiden name. If the almshouse gave the registrar what Ann had told them, this single sheet of paper could name her parents — and parents' names, run against the parish registers of our three candidate counties, are exactly what cracks Irish research open. This is the most important document left on earth for this family, and it is the first thing we are pursuing.

2. *Her grave in Utica.* The friends who claimed her body in 1905 buried her in Utica, almost certainly in Catholic ground — St. Agnes Cemetery is the strongest candidate. The cemetery's interment book for November 1905 would confirm it, and if the Owens family bought her a stone, stones of that era sometimes name a county in Ireland. Nobody has looked yet.

3. *Mary's baptism at St. Peter's, Rome.* Ann was Catholic, and St. Peter's was Rome's old Irish parish — records back to 1837, "most of the early parishioners of Irish descent." A February 1877 baptism for Mary is very likely in its register, and Irish priests of that era sometimes recorded a mother's home parish in the margin. The same parish's funeral register may also hold Ann's November 1905 burial. The records now rest with St. Mary's/St. Peter's parish and the Diocese of Syracuse archives.

4. *The unindexed almshouse books.* Our correspondence with the New York State Archives (September 2026) confirmed that the inmate-census series our two Ann forms came from has *no name index* — it is

arranged only by county, facility, and year. That means forms the databases never surfaced may still lie in the Oneida County reels: a readmission for Ann between 1877 and 1882, or a form for little Mary herself. We are paging through those years image by image.

5. *Mary's placement file.* The House of the Good Shepherd still operates in Utica today, and its 1880s placement ledgers — if they survive — would document how a Rome poorhouse toddler traveled 900 miles to a German Catholic merchant's house in Illinois. Monroe County, Illinois may hold the other end of that paper trail: a guardianship or adoption record for the Pfeffers, whose courthouse we have already written to.

In Ireland:

6. *The Catholic parish registers themselves.* The National Library of Ireland has photographed virtually every surviving Catholic register in the country, free to read online, and FamilySearch has indexed them by name. We are searching for the baptism of an Ann (or Anne, Anna, or Nancy) Blackwell — also spelled Blackwall and easily confused with Blackall — between 1844 and 1856, starting in Dunleer and its neighbor parishes, then Limerick, then Clare. Dunleer is a small rural parish; even reading it page by page is only a few hours' work, and we intend to do exactly that.

7. *The 1901 Irish census.* Ireland's censuses recorded religion, and the returns are free online. Mapping which Blackwell households in 1901 were Catholic will confirm which of our three clusters were Ann's kind of Blackwells — and may reveal cousins who stayed when she sailed.

If even two of these pieces fall together — a parent's name from the death certificate, a matching baptism in a parish register — we will know the very townland this family walked out of. And then someone in this family can stand on that ground.

Sources

1. 1880 U.S. Federal Census, Rome, Oneida County, N.Y., Oneida County Poorhouse: Mary Blackwell, age 3, and Ann Blackwell, age 32, same dwelling and page. NARA T9, roll 903, E.D. 112, p. 61B, dw. 90.
2. Record of Inmates, Oneida County Poor House: Ann Blackwell, admitted Sept. 30, 1876. Census of Inmates in Almshouses and Poorhouses, 1875–1921. N.Y. State Archives, Series A1978, reel A1978:147, record 446.
3. Record of Inmates, Oneida County Almshouse: Anna Blackwell, admitted Mar. 16, 1905. N.Y. State Archives, Series A1978, reel A1978:150, record 4115.
4. Passenger manifest, ship *Scotland*, Liverpool to New York, arrived May 28, 1866: Ann Blackwell, 15. NARA M237, roll 266; N.Y. Passenger Lists 1820–1957.
5. 1900 U.S. Federal Census, Utica Ward 11, Oneida Co., N.Y.: household of David E. Owens, 305 Sunset Ave., incl. Annie Blackwell, servant. Also 1900 census, Columbia, Monroe Co., Ill.: household of John A. Pfeffer, incl. “Jennie Pfeffer, adopted daughter.”
6. Utica city directories, 1889–1891: Anna Blackwell, laundress, rear 55 Charlotte St.

7. New York State death index: Anna Blackwell, Rome, Oct. 31, 1905, certificate no. 46049. Death notices, Rome Daily Sentinel, Oct. 31, 1905, and Utica Daily Press, Nov. 1, 1905.
8. *Portrait and Biographical Record of Randolph, Jackson, Perry and Monroe Counties, Illinois* (1894), biography of John A. Pfeffer, naming adopted daughter “Johanna Mary.”
9. Illinois County Marriage Records: Marietta Blackwell and Jacob Brand, Monroe County, 1904. U.S. Federal Censuses 1910, 1920, 1930, Jacob and Marietta Brand household.
10. Missouri Certificate of Death no. 37226, Maryetta Brand, Nov. 1, 1938, St. Louis. Missouri State Archives, digitized certificate 1938_00037233. Death notices, St. Louis newspapers, Nov. 4, 1938; Belleville (Ill.) Daily Advocate, Nov. 16, 1938.
11. Immaculate Conception Catholic Cemetery, Columbia, Ill., parish lot index: Brand graves row 6, Pfeffer graves row 5.
12. N.Y. Children’s Law of 1875 (ch. 173); N.Y. State Board of Charities annual reports on Oneida County practice. House of the Good Shepherd, Utica, institutional history.
13. Griffith’s Valuation of Ireland (1847–1864), Blackwell households by county; 1901 Census of Ireland surname and religion tabulations.
14. Photograph, women’s day room, Oneida County Almshouse, 1900. Harvard Art Museums / Fogg Museum.
15. U.S. Social Security Applications and Claims Index: claim of Vern Harry Brand naming mother “Mary Blackwel.”
16. Oral history of Bernadine (Brand) Babcock, as told to Robert Babcock.

All records cited are attached to the corresponding people in the Robert Babcock Family Tree on Ancestry, where the original document images can be viewed.

*For Ann, who crossed alone and was carried home by friends —
and for Bernadine, who never let us forget.*